persistence of the idea of Najibullah—known as the 'Najibullah Model'—in New Delhi's power circles as recently as 2013 (at least), as the US-led NATO troops began withdrawing from Afghanistan. This essentially meant developing a similar relationship with Karzai (or any other Afghan leader in Kabul) after the US withdrawal, as India had done with Najibullah. That the model failed without external financial support, and just about existed with such support, seemed lost on Indian policymakers.

In contrast to the widely believed notion of India's proxy war with Pakistan in Afghanistan, the 1980s reflect that India's Afghanistan policy was not necessarily, entirely, or consistently anti-Pakistan in its political outlook. Both Indira and Rajiv Gandhi wanted to work together with Pakistan. However, the contradictory systemic pressures generated by the Soviet invasion (that pushed India into adopting an anti-Pakistan posture), and Pakistan's rigid response to India's overtures, diminished the possibility of a rapprochement on the Afghan question. Moreover, the argument that India and Afghanistan collaborated overtly and covertly against Pakistan's interests during the 1980s, despite its credibility, cannot be stretched (as it often is) to say that India's Afghanistan policy is all about undermining Pakistan. Gandhi's lukewarm response to the 1982 Soviet proposal of wresting the rest of Kashmir back was one of the many instances when India refused to undermine Pakistan's security, sovereignty, and territorial integrity. New Delhi's approach towards Afghanistan, in fact, was nuanced in its motivation and careful in its intent throughout the 1980s, and as the following chapters show, remained as such over the decades. Pakistan's hardline stance in Afghanistan, much like the 1980s, also remained the same in the following decades.

Finally, the Soviet withdrawal shifted the framework in which Afghanistan was debated in India. Instead of debating on the lines of Cold War alignments or non-alignment, India's Afghanistan policy debate became increasingly focused on Pakistan and gave birth to the partisans and the conciliators. Should India engage with pro-Pakistan Mujahideen factions in Afghanistan? Should it limit contact only to those factions that are wary of, or openly at odds with, Pakistan? Should it maintain a presence in Afghanistan given the turbulence that country was witnessing or should it move out lock, stock, and barrel? These are question that